

Chapter 4

Healthy Waffles

Cody Overture woke up to a booming explosion from the other room. He groggily rolled out of his tangled sheets and fell off his rickety bed. Stretching his arm out from the floor, he slapped his alarm clock to silence. It tumbled to the floorboards as well. With the clock on the ground, he glanced at it and realized he had been asleep for eleven hours!

Shortly after, another fiery boom went off. It came from the kitchen. Cody got up and crept out to his family's small, homely kitchen. He saw his sister Olive making waffles with a chemistry lab set. Olive Overture was an ambitious 12-year old with a brain too big for her small head. Growing up in the middle of nowhere with all the encyclopedias and equipment manuals she could read, she picked up a bunch of useless knowledge. While most kids her age spoke in internet slang and TV show quotes, little Olive was sharing her profound thoughts on the economy, history, and the weather... the freaking weather. She was unapologetically herself, but she still took a lot after her family. And other times, she straight up took her family's belongings. Right now, she was wearing her mom's apron, her dad's old baseball cap (backwards), and Cody's new trout sweater.

"Oh fooey," she remarked, "This waffle recipe's gonna be the absolute death of me."

While Cody was thankful to eat something vegetarian after witnessing the slaughter of a creature, he was still curious on why his little sister would attempt to cook. She never made anything, not even burnt toast.

"What's with the batter bomb?" Cody asked.

"The first batch I had came out flat. It looked like a sad, plaid pancake." said Olive before blowing a lock of front hair from her face. It just instantly flopped back to where it was.

"Anyway, for the second batch, I thought I'd use science and test out some air-expansion methods for fluffier dough."

"There's tried and true methods *in the cook book*."

"Yeah, but those are boring. Now be a good brother and help clean up." said Olive, returning to stirring.

"It's your mess. You clean it up."

"Hey! I didn't have to make breakfast, ya know. Dad went to work early, and Mom's not back from the night shift yet."

Cody shook his head with a grin. He then grabbed a wet towel and started wiping up splattered batter from the walls. “They’ve been like that all week. Why’re you complaining now?”

“Because it wasn’t Saturday all those other days! We already skipped the healthy Saturday Waffles last week, and I refuse to skip it again this week.”

Olive reached out her chemistry kit and pulled out a bright green test tube. Before she could pour even a drop into the batter, Cody blocked her with his towel.

“Ol,if you really want pancakes, sit down. I’ll make ‘em for you. I know the way dad actually makes them.

“With cinnamon and bananas?” said Olive, arching an eyebrow.

“And a little bit of vanilla yogurt. Those are the easy ones to remember. Come on, Ol. Cody winked.

Olive smiled and yanked the towel from her brother’s hand. “I’ll clean my mess then. One day, I’ll be smart enough to run a company that can pay assistants. But until then, I’m stuck doing my grunt work.”

“Dream big, ya goof,” said Cody as he began a new batch of batter. “Hmm. Speaking of dreams, I had a strange one.”

“Did it involve a super intelligent politician-bear who solved the unemployment crisis in our country?”

“What? No! Was that your dream?”

“Maybe.”

“Well, mine involved a giant squirrel who ate a whole village.”

“Sounds boring.” Said Olive.

“It was horrifying! And then... um.... Nevermind.”

Olive’s eyes perked up. “Oh?”

“Yeah. Uh. I thought other stuff happened in the dream, but then I remembered nothing else happened.”

“Yeah, that sounds believable, alright.”

“Yeah, because it’s true.” Said Cody as he gingerly grabbed the first waffle out of the iron.

“Penny showed up. Didn’t she?”

Cody nearly spilled batter all over the counter after attempting to start the next waffle.

“What! No. Ew.” He said.

“And then she KISSED YOU. Didn’t she?”

“What books did mom let you start reading?”

“Was it all slobbery and gooey?”

“Okay, you know what, Olive, you got your wish. Breakfast is all yours. Feel free to make all the explosive healthy waffles you want.”

Cody slammed shut the waffle iron and marched out of the kitchen.

“Where are you going, huh?” asked Olive.

“To work! There’s no politician-bear solving the work crisis, so I can’t afford to lose my job.”

Olive shook her head as Cody booked it out of their small home. The slam from the front door seemingly shook every room. As the snarky, little genius poured some batter onto the waffle iron, she smiled and giggled to herself, “That boy is out of control.”